

Skills That Matter

AI can produce a first draft of almost anything in seconds. That changes what makes a person valuable. The most important skills aren't producing the first version anymore. They're deciding what to ask, judging whether the answer is good, catching what's wrong, choosing what matters, and owning the final call. The bottleneck moves from production to direction.

You've been building these moves all course. The human edge is knowing which one to bring in at which moment.

WHAT AI DOES VS. WHAT YOU DO

CHEAP AND ABUNDANT NOW

What AI does fast

- First drafts of almost anything
- Summaries of long text
- Generating ten options
- Reformatting and rewriting
- Routine code and boilerplate
- Surface-level explanations

SCARCE AND VALUABLE NOW

What still depends on you

- Knowing what question to ask
- Deciding whether the answer is good
- Catching weak reasoning
- Verifying what matters
- Choosing what's actually important
- Owning the final call

THE QUESTION TO ASK YOURSELF FIRST

Before you type a prompt, ask: what decision stays with me?

Some prompts are low-stakes. Background music, a quick title, a summary you'll forget in an hour. Let AI handle it.

Some aren't. What to write your college essay about. Whether to submit something as your own work. How to handle a hard conversation. AI can help you think it through. The call is still yours.

Naming which kind you're making before you prompt is the difference between using AI and outsourcing yourself.

SKILLS THAT GAIN VALUE

Each one of these used to be invisible: just "good thinking." In a world where AI handles the typing, they're the actual job.



Ask better questions

AI output is bounded by the prompt. Vague in, vague out. Knowing what you want, why, and in what form is itself a skill, and one most people are bad at.



Judge output quality

AI sounds fluent every time. The harder skill is recognizing when fluent isn't the same as right, useful, or honest.



Spot weak reasoning

AI often skips steps, assumes the conclusion, or sounds confident about a shaky claim. Noticing that is on you, not the model.



Verify what matters

AI generates what sounds true, not what is true. The better it sounds, the more important it becomes to check the things that actually matter.



Break down messy problems

Real problems don't arrive as clean prompts. Splitting a tangled question into pieces AI can actually help with is the work AI won't do for you.



Apply real domain knowledge

AI knows a little about everything. People who know one thing deeply can catch mistakes, push back, and steer AI toward genuinely better answers.



Taste, judgment, prioritization

AI can hand you ten options. Picking the right one, and knowing why, is what separates good work from average work.



Know when not to trust it

The most valuable instinct is the one that says, "this sounds confident, but I shouldn't act on it yet." Calibration beats blind trust.

FOUR MOVES AI CAN'T OWN FOR YOU



Frame the real problem

AI is much more useful when the human knows what needs to be solved, who it is for, and what a good answer would look like.



Make sense of weird behavior

When you know that AI works through patterns, probability, context, and prediction, its weird behavior starts to make sense.



Check what matters

AI can sound confident when it is wrong. The better it sounds, the more important it becomes to know what needs verification.



Make the human call

AI can generate options. It cannot own your judgment, your values, your reputation, or the consequences of what you choose.

Each of these weird AI results really happened. See if you can spot the human move that was missing.



AI makes production cheaper. That makes direction, judgment, and ownership more valuable. The skills above don't replace AI. They're what makes AI worth using.

Some skills stay yours.

That's where your value compounds.